and bear markets. That is where advisors earn their keep and investors set up their futures.

Get what you pay for

For many people, hiring a professional makes sense. If you have complex tax issues, if your financial situation is complicated with ex-spouses and children, if you are concerned with generational wealth transfer, the sale of a business, or have questions about philanthropy and gifts, then you probably need help.

But don't pay me or anyone else for services unless you make full use of them. After you complete your financial plan, go through it regularly (at least once a year, more often when things change). Consult with us on taxes, estate planning, insurance coverage, security, and anything with a financial element. If you are having an issue, the odds are that we have seen something similar, if not identical, before.

It surprises me how often people fail to take full advantage of the services they pay for.

Be a long-term thinker

Bull markets tend to pull gains forward from the decade ahead. It is during secular bear markets (e.g., 2000–2013) where the real money is made. Anyone who upped their stock purchases during that period and rode out the long bear made out like a bandit in the 2010s. It will feel terrible for a decade, but it is worth it.

Start thinking in terms of decades, not months or minutes.

Misunderstanding the nature of risk

A good definition of risk is the probability of not getting your expected returns.